

- 3.c) Evaluate the debates around the use of participant observation as a research method in anthropology. What are the ethical and methodological controversies associated with this approach? (15 marks)

Participant observation as a research strategy involves researcher ~~become~~ learning the local language and becoming an active participant in the native's culture in an attempt to objectively study their culture.

The method was perfected by B. Malinowski in his study of Trobriland Islanders.

Merits of Participant Observation

- ① Helps in observing native's in natural habitat and hence more likely to exhibit natural behaviour.
- ② Making research more objective.
- ③ Getting access to sensitive aspects of culture which otherwise is not available

- ④ Getting closer to the native's point of view (emic view)
- ⑤ Drawing generalisation and making theories.

Debates surrounding the method and various ethical and methodological controversies:-

- ① Questionable Objectivity: There is a chance that researcher may get emotionally attached during participation leading to bias.
- ② Further, the native's in the presence of the outsider may ~~not reveal~~ alter their natural behaviour leading to incorrect data collection.
- ③ Purpose of the research: During colonial times, many researches ~~are~~ like the one done by Malinowski was

used by colonial empires to expand their influence on distant tobes.

④ The method involves intense time and cost for successful completion.

⑤ Post Modernist critique: They criticised the method as not objective as it involved power hierarchies and vested interests to serve the needs of those in power.

Conclusion

Participant Observation has its set of limitations but it still remains as the most important method for qualitative research.

Following reflexivity, i.e. acknowledging one's bias and "attached detachment" as suggested by Clyde Kluckhohn can ensure more and more objectivity in the method.